The 15-point claim readiness checklist

R&D TAX RELIEF | BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

Use these 15 checks to review the technical, financial and procedural readiness of your R&D claim. They cover eligibility and the applicable scheme, project explanations and competent professionals, qualifying expenditure, funding and contractual arrangements, and evidence and submission requirements.

This is a readiness check, not an eligibility score. Tick a box when the point has been checked and documented. Resolve gaps before submission; a completed checklist does not establish entitlement to relief.

Company: _____

Accounting period: _____

Prepared by: _____

Reviewed by: _____

Review date: _____

1. Eligibility and applicable scheme

GUIDANCE Assess the company, accounting period and applicable relief before preparing the claim.

1. Have you confirmed the company's eligibility, accounting period and applicable R&D scheme, including any scheme-specific conditions?	☐
2. Does each project clearly explain the scientific or technological advance sought against the existing knowledge or capability in the field?	☐
3. Are the uncertainties explained, including why their resolution was not readily available or deducible by a competent professional?	☐

2. Project scope and technical review

GUIDANCE Explain the work in enough detail to support the claim. Identify the relevant expertise, the qualifying project boundaries and the investigations undertaken, rather than relying on a job title or assertion of innovation.

4. Is a relevant competent professional identified for each project, with their qualifications, experience and reasoned technical assessment recorded?	☐
5. Are the qualifying R&D start and end points identified, with routine, commercial and other non-qualifying activities distinguished?	☐
6. Does the project account describe the approach, tests, iterations and results, including unresolved uncertainties or unsuccessful work?	☐

3. Qualifying costs and activities

GUIDANCE Link expenditure to qualifying activities and apply the rules for the period and scheme. Check restrictions, exclusions and calculations, not just whether an invoice exists. Retain evidence on how the judgements made on R&D eligibility and apportionments have been made.

7. Do costs map to qualifying activities, including separately identified qualifying indirect activities where applicable?	☐
8. Are expenditure categories, staff-time allocations, other costs apportionments and estimates supported, with non-qualifying amounts and duplicates excluded?	☐
9. Do claim workings reconcile to the accounting records, with applicable rates, limits and PAYE cap or	☐

exemption checked?

4. Contracts, contracted-out expenditure and overseas costs

GUIDANCE Review contractual entitlement separately from the costs claimed. Check contractor and externally provided worker expenditure under the rules for the relevant period and scheme, identify where the work took place, and retain evidence supporting the treatment of overseas costs and any exception relied on.

10. Have contracts and surrounding circumstances been reviewed to establish who is entitled to claim for R&D contracted out by or to the company? ☐

11. Are contractor and externally provided worker costs separately identified, apportioned to qualifying activities and calculated under the applicable scheme rules? ☐

12. Have the locations of contractor and externally provided worker activities been recorded, with overseas cost restrictions checked and any exception supported by evidence? ☐

5. Evidence, deadlines and submission

GUIDANCE Keep a retrievable evidence trail. Check procedural requirements as well as eligibility: submit the additional information form before the Company Tax Return containing the claim, even when both are sent on the same day.

13. Can you produce dated project and financial records supporting the work, its timing and costs, with retrospective explanations clearly identified? ☐

14. Have claim submission and claim notification (relevant only until 31 March 2027) deadlines been checked, or a documented exception established? ☐

15. Is the additional information form complete and consistent with the claim, with submission before the CT600 arranged and company approval and final filing checks completed? ☐

WHAT NEXT?

Record unresolved issues, assign an owner and resolve significant gaps before submission. Seek specialist review where eligibility, contracts, calculations or filing requirements remain uncertain.

Issue / action: _____

Owner: _____

Due date: _____

General information only. This checklist is not exhaustive and does not determine entitlement to relief. Requirements depend on the facts, accounting period, scheme and applicable law. November 2026.

HMRC guidance — checked 5 November 2026
GfC3: Expectations of claimants
GfC3: Claims and record keeping
Merged RDEC and enhanced R&D intensive support
Merged scheme reform and subsidised expenditure
Claim notification requirements
Additional information form requirements